

Long before the medal came, there was appetite

From afternoon hill runs in Haryana to defeating a former world champion at the Asian Championships, 20-year-old sensation **Priya Ghanghas**' journey reflects the grit and ambition driving India's next generation of women's boxing.

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By her own reckoning, Priya Ghanghas made the most of the short break between her return from the Asian Boxing Championships in Mongolia and the resumption of the Indian national women's boxing camp in Patiala last month. The 20-year-old indulged in her *maa ke haath ka churma*, playtime with Raja, whom she picked up as a pup from the street three years ago, banter with her parents and brother, motorcycle rides and plenty of long sleep-ins.

"I won't get to do any of this for a long time, so I have to enjoy it while I can," she tells *Sportstar* in Bhiwani, her hometown.

Although it's something she can do anywhere, there's one thing Priya enjoys more than anything else. Every so often, she says, she pulls out her mobile phone and watches a

video recording. It's of her bout against former world champion Chengyu Yang of China in the quarterfinals of the Asian Elite Boxing Championships 2026.

"She watches that bout constantly. Sometimes, even we wonder what she's seeing in it," says her father, Mahendra.

Priya agrees.

"I think I've watched it around 40-50 times. I watch it three or four times a day. I think it's the best I have boxed. I was boxing against a world champion and a very senior boxer. But I showed complete confidence in my skills. I was trailing after the first round, but I trusted myself and dominated the next two rounds," she says.

That fight, which she clinched with a 4-1 split decision, was career-defining for Priya. The result assured her of a medal at the Asian Championships. The two more wins that followed, against Mongolia's Namuun Monkhon and then North

Korea's Won Un-gyong in the final, sealed a gold medal in the women's 60kg category. It made Priya, who at just over 20 years old was competing in her first senior international tournament, the youngest Indian champion at the Continental Championships. According to the selection policy of the Boxing Federation of India, Priya also earned a spot on the Indian squad for the Asian Games later this year.

It's the kind of breakthrough not many might have predicted even a few years back.

Slow start

Coach Mahavir Singh recalls having his doubts three years ago when Mahendra attempted to secure Priya's admission to the Boxing Academy at the Sports Authority of India Centre in Bhiwani. The academy, where Olympians including Akhil Kumar, Vijender Kumar, Manish Kaushik, Raj Kumar Sangwan and Vikas Krishan Yadav